

Question ID: f1bfbed3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

Marta Coll and colleagues’ 2010 Mediterranean Sea biodiversity census reported approximately 17,000 species, nearly double the number reported in Carlo Bianchi and Carla Morri’s 2000 census—a difference only partly attributable to the description of new invertebrate species in the interim. Another factor is that the morphological variability of microorganisms is poorly understood compared to that of vertebrates, invertebrates, plants, and algae, creating uncertainty about how to evaluate microorganisms as species. Researchers’ decisions on such matters therefore can be highly consequential. Indeed, the two censuses reported similar counts of vertebrate, plant, and algal species, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. Coll and colleagues reported a much higher number of species than Bianchi and Morri did largely due to the inclusion of invertebrate species that had not been described at the time of Bianchi and Morri’s census.
- B. some differences observed in microorganisms may have been treated as variations within species by Bianchi and Morri but treated as indicative of distinct species by Coll and colleagues.
- C. Bianchi and Morri may have been less sensitive to the degree of morphological variation displayed within a typical species of microorganism than Coll and colleagues were.
- D. the absence of clarity regarding how to differentiate among species of microorganisms may have resulted in Coll and colleagues underestimating the number of microorganism species.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically completes the text’s discussion of the different counts of species in the Mediterranean Sea. The text states that Coll and colleagues reported almost double the number of species that Bianchi and Morri reported in their study ten years earlier. According to the text, this difference can only be partly attributed to new invertebrate species being described in the years between the two studies, which means there must be an additional factor that made Coll and colleagues’ count so much higher than Bianchi and Morri’s count. The text goes on to explain that factor: researchers have a relatively poor understanding of microorganisms’ morphological variability, or the differences in microorganisms’ structure and form. This poor understanding makes it hard to classify microorganisms by species and means that researchers’ decisions about classifying microorganisms can have a large effect on the overall species counts that researchers report. Additionally, the text says that the two censuses reported similar numbers of vertebrate, plant, and algal species, which means that the difference in overall species did not come from differences in those categories. Given all this information, it most logically follows that Coll and colleagues may have treated some of the differences among microorganisms as indicative of the microorganisms being different species, whereas Bianchi and Morri treated those differences as variations within species, resulting in Coll and colleagues reporting many more species than Bianchi and Morri did.

Choice A is incorrect because the text explicitly addresses this issue by stating that the description of new invertebrate species in the years between the two studies can explain only part of the difference in the number of species reported by the studies. The focus of the text is on explaining the difference between Coll and colleagues’ count and Bianchi and Morri’s count that cannot be accounted for by the inclusion of invertebrate species that had not been described at the time of Bianchi and Morri’s study. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that Bianchi and Morri may have been less sensitive to how much the form and structure of microorganisms vary within the same species than Coll and colleagues were. If Bianchi and Morri had been less sensitive to within-species variation than Coll and colleagues were, Bianchi and Morri would likely have reported more species than Coll and colleagues did, since less sensitivity to within-species variation would

lead researchers to classify as different species microorganisms that more sensitive researchers would classify as variations within the same species. The text indicates, however, that Bianchi and Morri reported far fewer species than Coll and colleagues did; since the text also excludes other explanations for this difference, it suggests that in fact Bianchi and Morri were more sensitive to within-species variation than Coll and colleagues were, leading Bianchi and Morri to report fewer overall species. Choice D is incorrect because the text is focused on explaining why Coll and colleagues reported many more species than Bianchi and Morri did, and an underestimate of the number of microorganism species by Coll and colleagues would not explain that difference—it would suggest, in fact, that the difference in the number of species should have been even larger.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

In her 2021 article “Throwaway History: Towards a Historiography of Ephemera,” scholar Anne Garner discusses John Johnson (1882–1956), a devoted collector of items intended to be discarded, including bus tickets and campaign pamphlets. Johnson recognized that scholarly institutions considered his expansive collection of ephemera to be worthless—indeed, it wasn’t until 1968, after Johnson’s death, that Oxford University’s Bodleian Library acquired the collection, having grasped the items’ potential value to historians and other researchers. Hence, the example of Johnson serves to _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. demonstrate the difficulties faced by contemporary historians in conducting research at the Bodleian Library without access to ephemera.
- B. represent the challenge of incorporating examples of ephemera into the collections of libraries and other scholarly institutions.
- C. lend support to arguments by historians and other researchers who continue to assert that ephemera holds no value for scholars.
- D. illustrate both the relatively low scholarly regard in which ephemera was once held and the later recognition of ephemera’s possible utility.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Johnson collected “ephemera,” or things that are meant to be thrown away. Scholars thought his collection was worthless to them, then later realized that it was potentially valuable. This suggests that scholars went from disregarding ephemera to recognizing their usefulness.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text tells us that the Bodleian Library acquired Johnson’s large collection of ephemera back in 1968, so we can assume that contemporary historians conducting research there do have access to that collection. Choice B is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text tells us that “Oxford University’s Bodleian Library acquired the collection,” but it never suggests that it was a challenge to do so. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text actually suggests the opposite: the example of Johnson’s collection lends support to arguments that ephemera does hold value for scholars.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

One recognized social norm of gift giving is that the time spent obtaining a gift will be viewed as a reflection of the gift’s thoughtfulness. Marketing experts Farnoush Reshadi, Julian Givi, and Gopal Das addressed this view in their studies of norms specifically surrounding the giving of gift cards, noting that while recipients tend to view digital gift cards (which can be purchased online from anywhere and often can be redeemed online as well) as superior to physical gift cards (which sometimes must be purchased in person and may only be redeemable in person) in terms of usage, 94.8 percent of participants surveyed indicated that it is more socially acceptable to give a physical gift card to a recipient. This finding suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. gift givers likely overestimate the amount of effort required to use digital gift cards and thus mistakenly assume gift recipients will view them as less desirable than physical gift cards.
- B. physical gift cards are likely preferred by gift recipients because the tangible nature of those cards offers a greater psychological sense of ownership than digital gift cards do.
- C. physical gift cards are likely less desirable to gift recipients than digital gift cards are because of the perception that physical gift cards require unnecessary effort to obtain.
- D. gift givers likely perceive digital gift cards as requiring relatively low effort to obtain and thus wrongly assume gift recipients will appreciate them less than they do physical gift cards.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of perceptions of digital versus physical gift cards. The text begins by explaining that the perception of "the time spent obtaining a gift...as a reflection of the gift’s thoughtfulness" is a social norm of gift giving. The text then explains that although those who receive digital gift cards view them as easier to use than physical gift cards, a marketing study nonetheless showed that 94.8% of participants found physical gift cards more "socially acceptable" to give. The text specifically contrasts the ease with which digital gift cards "can be purchased online from anywhere" with the fact that physical gift cards "sometimes must be purchased in person"—suggesting the greater difficulty of obtaining physical cards. Given the text’s initial premise that gift-giving norms equate the thoughtfulness of a gift with the effort involved in acquiring that gift, it is reasonable to infer that people perceive digital gift cards as requiring less effort to obtain and thus assume recipients will appreciate them less, even though recipients actually prefer gift cards in the more usable digital format.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text does discuss recipients’ preference of digital versus physical gift cards and the relative ease with which the two formats can be used, it doesn’t consider the misconceptions that gift givers may have of these factors. Moreover, the text establishes that recipients regard digital gift cards as easier to use and therefore preferable to physical gift cards. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t consider whether recipients of gift cards feel a sense of ownership toward them, nor does the text touch on the greater tangibility of physical versus digital gift cards. Instead, the text contrasts the two formats of gift cards in terms of their respective usability and the difficulty involved in acquiring them and discusses how those factors influence people’s perceptions of the two formats. Choice C is incorrect because it contradicts the text, which explains that recipients regard digital gift cards as superior to physical ones because they are easier to use than physical cards, not because physical gift cards require greater effort to obtain than digital gift cards do. Moreover, the text doesn’t characterize the effort required to obtain physical gift cards as "unnecessary."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

The practice of logging (cutting down trees for commercial and other uses) is often thought to be at odds with forest conservation (the work of preserving forests). However, a massive study in forest management and preservation spanning 700,000 hectares in Oregon’s Malheur National Forest calls that view into question. So far, results of the study suggest that forest plots that have undergone limited logging (the careful removal of a controlled number of trees) may be more robust than plots that haven’t been logged at all. These results, in turn, suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. logging may be useful for maintaining healthy forests, provided it is limited.
- B. other forest management strategies are more effective than limited logging.
- C. as time passes, it will be difficult to know whether limited logging has any benefits.
- D. the best way to support forest health may be to leave large forests entirely untouched.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the potential effects of logging on forest conservation. The text begins by stating that logging practices are often thought of as being contrary to forest conservation efforts. Then, the text presents the results of a research study examining the effect of limited logging practices on specific forest plots, finding that the plots with limited logging may be "more robust" (healthier) than the plots that hadn’t been logged at all. Given these results, it follows that logging may be a useful practice for maintaining healthy forests if it is practiced in a limited way.

Choice B is incorrect because the study referenced in the text only provides information on limited logging as a potential forest management strategy. There is no information in the text about how other forest management strategies support forest conservation efforts. Therefore, the text does not support the assertion that other forest management strategies are more successful than limited logging. Choice C is incorrect because the text presents a research study with findings that specific plots of forest with limited logging may be more robust than the forest plots that were not logged. Rather than suggesting that it is hard to know whether limited logging might be beneficial, the text suggests that the practice could be useful in forest conservation efforts. Choice D is incorrect. The text discusses the results of a research study that compares the health of forest plots with limited logging to forest plots that were not logged. It does not take a position on the best way to support forest health but rather presents a research study with findings that question conventionally held thoughts regarding the practice of logging.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

Researchers recently found that disruptions to an enjoyable experience, like a short series of advertisements during a television show, often increase viewers’ reported enjoyment. Suspecting that disruptions to an unpleasant experience would have the opposite effect, the researchers had participants listen to construction noise for 30 minutes and anticipated that those whose listening experience was frequently interrupted with short breaks of silence would thus _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. find the disruptions more irritating as time went on.
- B. rate the listening experience as more negative than those whose listening experience was uninterrupted.
- C. rate the experience of listening to construction noise as lasting for less time than it actually lasted.
- D. perceive the volume of the construction noise as growing softer over time.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. It most logically completes the text. The text tells us that disruptions to an enjoyable experience increase viewers’ enjoyment. It also says that researchers suspect the opposite is true for disruptions to an unpleasant experience. Thus, we can infer that the researchers expect to find that the interrupted unpleasant experience was worse for listeners than the uninterrupted unpleasant experience.

Choice A is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text never makes any claims about how irritating the disruptions themselves are perceived to be. Rather, the text says that pleasant experiences are perceived as more enjoyable with interruptions, and that the opposite is suspected to be true of unpleasant experiences. Choice C is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text never makes any claims about how long any experience is perceived to be. Rather, the text says that pleasant experiences are perceived as more enjoyable with interruptions, and that the opposite is suspected to be true of unpleasant experiences. Choice D is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text never makes any claims about how interruptions affect the perceived volume of the unpleasant or pleasant experience. Rather, the text says that pleasant experiences are perceived as more enjoyable with interruptions, and that the opposite is suspected to be true of unpleasant experiences.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

Many of William Shakespeare’s tragedies address broad themes that still appeal to today’s audiences. For instance, *Romeo and Juliet*, which is set in the Italy of Shakespeare’s time, tackles the themes of parents versus children and love versus hate, and the play continues to be read and produced widely around the world. But understanding Shakespeare’s so-called history plays can require a knowledge of several centuries of English history. Consequently, _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. many theatergoers and readers today are likely to find Shakespeare’s history plays less engaging than the tragedies.
- B. some of Shakespeare’s tragedies are more relevant to today’s audiences than twentieth-century plays.
- C. *Romeo and Juliet* is the most thematically accessible of all Shakespeare’s tragedies.
- D. experts in English history tend to prefer Shakespeare’s history plays to his other works.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the relative appeal of different kinds of plays by Shakespeare to today’s audiences. According to the text, Shakespeare’s tragedies address broad themes that continue to appeal to today’s audiences. Indeed, the text suggests that these themes are timeless, as illustrated by the example of *Romeo and Juliet*, which the text states is still read and widely performed despite being set in the Italy of Shakespeare’s time. In contrast, the text indicates that audiences and readers may need to be familiar with several centuries of English history in order to understand Shakespeare’s history plays. Because many theatergoers and readers are unlikely to possess such extensive historical knowledge, it follows that they are likely to find Shakespeare’s history plays less engaging than his more accessible tragedies.

Choice B is incorrect because the text never introduces a comparison between Shakespeare’s tragedies and twentieth-century plays, only between Shakespeare’s tragedies and his history plays. Since twentieth-century plays aren’t mentioned, there’s no basis in the text for the idea that some of Shakespeare’s tragedies are more relevant than twentieth-century plays to today’s audiences. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text indicates that *Romeo and Juliet* is thematically accessible to today’s audiences, it doesn’t suggest that *Romeo and Juliet* is more accessible than Shakespeare’s other tragedies. Rather, the text presents *Romeo and Juliet* as an example to support the idea that Shakespeare’s tragedies hold continued appeal for today’s readers and theatergoers. Choice D is incorrect. Although experts in English history would likely possess the knowledge needed to understand Shakespeare’s history plays, the text never mentions such experts or suggests that they would enjoy the history plays more than Shakespeare’s other works.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

The *Mammillaria* cactus *M. boolii* occurs naturally only in the state of Sonora in Mexico, and the smallness of its range makes it especially vulnerable to extinction. The traditional single-species approach to conservation emphasizes the need to focus on individual species most at risk, like *M. boolii*, but recently, conservationists have argued that an ecosystem-based approach that incorporates the many interactions between the climate, terrain, and various species of a given geographical area may lead to better outcomes for all the species in a given location. If this view is correct, the single-species approach to the conservation of *M. boolii* could thus _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. lead to a better understanding of how the distribution of *Mammillaria* species throughout Mexico has affected their survival.
- B. allow conservationists to better consider how climatic changes affecting Sonora may reduce the number of species competing with *M. boolii*.
- C. erroneously shift the focus of conservation efforts away from *M. boolii* itself.
- D. fail to consider the ways in which the survival of *M. boolii* may be influenced by changes in the populations of other species that inhabit Sonora.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of conservation approaches for the *Mammillaria* cactus *M. boolii*. The text establishes that *M. boolii* only grows naturally in the state of Sonora in Mexico, which makes it particularly vulnerable to extinction. The text then contrasts two approaches to conservation: the traditional single-species approach that individually focuses on at-risk species and a newer ecosystem-based approach that considers the interactions between climate, terrain, and various species in a geographical area. According to the text, conservationists have recently argued that this ecosystem-based approach may lead to better outcomes for all species in a location. If this ecosystem view is correct, then the single-species approach to conserving *M. boolii* would likely fail to consider how the cactus’s survival depends on its interactions with other species in Sonora’s ecosystem.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the distribution of *Mammillaria* species besides *M. boolii* throughout Mexico or discuss how that distribution affects survival. The text focuses specifically on *M. boolii* in Sonora and different approaches to its conservation. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that climatic changes in Sonora would reduce competition for *M. boolii* or that conservation efforts are focused on understanding this specific dynamic. In fact, the text implies that an ecosystem-based approach would consider climate among many other factors but doesn’t specify how climatic changes might affect competition between species. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the single-species approach would shift the focus of conservation efforts away from *M. boolii* itself—rather, it suggests that this approach might be too narrowly focused on *M. boolii* alone without considering the broader ecosystem-related factors that affect its survival.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

In the early nineteenth century, some Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States used agricultural techniques developed by the Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) people centuries earlier, but it seems that few of those farmers had actually seen Haudenosaunee farms firsthand. Barring the possibility of several farmers of the same era independently developing techniques that the Haudenosaunee people had already invented, these facts most strongly suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. those farmers learned the techniques from other people who were more directly influenced by Haudenosaunee practices.
- B. the crops typically cultivated by Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States were not well suited to Haudenosaunee farming techniques.
- C. Haudenosaunee farming techniques were widely used in regions outside the northeastern United States.
- D. Euro-American farmers only began to recognize the benefits of Haudenosaunee farming techniques late in the nineteenth century.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Euro-American farmers’ use of Haudenosaunee agricultural techniques. According to the text, some Euro-American farmers were using these techniques in the early nineteenth century despite few of the farmers having seen Haudenosaunee farms. One explanation for these facts might be that the farmers developed techniques on their own that already had been invented centuries earlier by the Haudenosaunee people, but the text explicitly bars, or rules out, this explanation. If Euro-American farmers didn’t learn these techniques from direct observation of Haudenosaunee practices and didn’t invent the techniques independently, then the most logical explanation is that they learned the techniques from other people who were more directly influenced by Haudenosaunee practices than the farmers themselves were. Once they learned about Haudenosaunee agricultural practices, Euro-American farmers could then apply those practices to their own farming.

Choice B is incorrect because the fact that some Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States were using Haudenosaunee techniques suggests that the techniques were likely useful for the crops the farmers raised, not that the crops typically cultivated by the farmers were not well suited to Haudenosaunee farming techniques. If the farmers’ crops were ill suited to the techniques, it’s unlikely that the farmers would have used those techniques. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates only that Haudenosaunee agricultural techniques were used by Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States, not that these techniques were widely used outside this region. Choice D is incorrect because the text states that some Euro-American farmers were using Haudenosaunee farming techniques early in the nineteenth century. This suggests that some Euro-American farmers were beginning to recognize the benefits of these techniques near the start of the century, not that such farmers only began to recognize the benefits of the techniques much later.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

Some businesses believe that when employees are interrupted while doing their work, they experience a decrease in energy and productivity. However, a team led by Harshad Puranik, who studies management, has found that interruptions by colleagues can have a social component that increases employees’ sense of belonging, resulting in greater job satisfaction that benefits employees and employers. Therefore, businesses should recognize that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. the interpersonal benefits of some interruptions in the workplace may offset the perceived negative effects.
- B. in order to maximize productivity, employers should be willing to interrupt employees frequently throughout the day.
- C. most employees avoid interrupting colleagues because they don’t appreciate being interrupted themselves.
- D. in order to cultivate an ideal workplace environment, interruptions of work should be discouraged.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of potential benefits of interruptions in the workplace. The text indicates that a common belief in business is that interruptions to working employees decrease energy and productivity levels. However, the text goes on to explain that a research team led by Harshad Puranik has found that there could be a social benefit to these interruptions. Since the team found that workplace interruptions can increase employees’ sense of belonging and job satisfaction, it follows that the interpersonal benefits of some interruptions can offset the perceived negative effects.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the text presents research findings that suggest some workplace interruptions can have a positive effect on employee job satisfaction, no further information is presented to suggest at what frequency these interruptions are ideal. Furthermore, the text doesn’t tie workplace interruptions to increased productivity, but rather links it to social benefits such as sense of belonging. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t address employees’ motives for choosing not to interrupt their colleagues. The text presents research findings that suggest that there are some positive interpersonal effects of workplace interruptions that can increase employee job satisfaction. Choice D is incorrect because asking businesses to discourage workplace interruptions doesn’t follow from the team’s research about the benefits of workplace interruptions, nor does the text describe an ideal work environment. Instead, the text presents research suggesting that there may be positive aspects to workplace interruptions that haven’t previously been considered.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

Some geologists have proposed designating the period from 1950 to the present as a new geological epoch (the Anthropocene) characterized by human impact on Earth, but they have struggled to identify reliable stratigraphic markers of the epoch’s onset. Inta Dimante-Deimantovica and a research team investigated whether the initial appearance of primary microplastics—invented and mass-produced for industrial and other purposes, beginning around the middle of the twentieth century—in sedimentary layers could serve this role. The researchers analyzed European lake sediment profiles from the late eighteenth century to the present. Microplastics were present in all layers, likely because certain microplastic shapes enabled rapid downward migration. The researchers therefore concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. the lowest sedimentary layer in which microplastics are found cannot be treated as indicative of the chronological beginning of the Anthropocene.
- B. the presence of microplastics in sediment dating to the late eighteenth century casts doubt on the appropriateness of designating 1950 as the onset of the Anthropocene.
- C. microplastics are not prevalent enough in sediment to serve as a reliable sign of the human impact characteristic of the Anthropocene.
- D. using the earliest presence of microplastics as a stratigraphic marker of the beginning of the Anthropocene is likely to be viable in some locations but is not viable in Europe.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of microplastics as a proposed stratigraphic marker for the onset of the Anthropocene. The text indicates that although primary microplastics (used for industrial and other purposes) were invented and mass-produced beginning only around the mid-twentieth century, researchers found microplastics throughout European lake sediment profiles dating from the late eighteenth century to the present. According to the text, microplastics were in all layers of sediment likely because microplastics of certain shapes can rapidly migrate downward—that is, they can move into sedimentary layers that predate their manufacture. Since it can’t be assumed that the date of a layer in which microplastics are found indicates when the microplastics were first deposited, it follows that the lowest sedimentary layer containing microplastics can’t be treated as indicative of the chronological beginning of the Anthropocene.

Choice B is incorrect. The text explains that microplastics appeared in layers of sediment long predating 1950 likely because certain shapes allowed them to rapidly migrate downward—that is, the particles physically moved into older layers. This finding doesn’t cast doubt on the appropriateness of considering 1950 as the onset of the Anthropocene; it doesn’t suggest a flaw in thinking that humans’ impact on Earth shifted around 1950 but simply suggests that the position of microplastics in sediment isn’t useful as an indicator of such a shift. Choice C is incorrect because the issue presented in the text isn’t a lack of prevalence of microplastics (and though no quantity is indicated, microplastics were found across all the layers) but rather the inability to determine when microplastics were originally deposited, since the particles can migrate rapidly into older sediment layers. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that the likely cause of microplastics being present in all layers of the sediment profiles is a property of microplastic particles themselves (certain shapes allowing them to rapidly move downward into older layers), not a characteristic of European lake sediment or anything else specific to Europe. There’s no reason to think the issue of particle migration wouldn’t occur in other locations.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

Like many other genera of wild bees, bumblebees have in recent decades experienced population collapse caused by, among other factors, habitat destruction and climate variation. Bumblebees are also one of the most researched bee genera, second only to honeybees. As a result, ecologists have gained much of their insight about wild-bee declines from bumblebees. In a 2021 paper, zoologist Guillaume Ghisbain notes that bumblebees are among the relatively few wild-bee genera that display social behaviors and dietary generalism (ability to obtain nectar and pollen from a diversity of plant species), two traits that are associated with increased resilience to some specific environmental changes. Ghisbain therefore contends that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. although bumblebees and many other wild bees have experienced similar population declines in the past, compared with other wild bees, bumblebees are likely at greater risk of being harmed by climate variation than by habitat destruction.
- B. although bumblebees have been more extensively studied than most wild bees, researchers should not use bumblebees to draw conclusions about the decline of other wild bees, even ones with feeding patterns and levels of sociability that are similar to those of bumblebees.
- C. because bumblebees and other bees with generalist diets are less negatively affected by environmental stress than bees with specialized diets are, they are less likely to experience major population changes in the future than bees with specialized diets are.
- D. because the responses of bumblebees and other wild bees to environmental threats are not always comparable, researchers need to exercise caution when extrapolating information about wild-bee population declines from bumblebees.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of wild-bee declines. The text establishes that bumblebees and other wild bees have been experiencing population collapse as a result of habitat destruction, climate variation, and other factors. The text then indicates that because bumblebees are very extensively researched, ecologists rely heavily on findings about them to understand wild-bee declines in general. However, the text then introduces Ghisbain’s observation that unlike most other wild-bee genera, bumblebees have certain traits (social behaviors and dietary generalism) linked to increased resilience to certain environmental changes. In other words, bumblebees aren’t necessarily representative of wild bees as a whole because they are likely more tolerant of some pressures. Therefore, it logically follows that Ghisbain would urge researchers to exercise caution when using bumblebee data to draw conclusions about other wild-bee population declines, since bumblebees and other wild bees don’t always respond comparably to environmental threats.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that climate variation is more of a threat to bumblebees than habitat destruction is or that it is a bigger threat to bumblebees than it is to other wild bees. The text simply indicates that climate variation and habitat destruction are among the factors that have caused population collapses for bumblebees and other wild-bee genera. Choice B is incorrect. As it is presented in the text, Ghisbain notes that bumblebees may respond to environmental changes differently than many other wild-bee genera do; this suggests that bumblebees shouldn’t be treated as representative of all wild bees, but there’s no reason to think that Ghisbain would go so far as to assert that bumblebee data shouldn’t be used to draw conclusions about other wild-bee genera that are similar to bumblebees in their dietary and social traits, even if there are relatively few. The text suggests caution in extrapolation, not a complete rejection of using bumblebee research. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text indicates that dietary generalism is linked to increased resilience to specific environmental changes (that is, to some but not all environmental stresses), it doesn’t suggest that bumblebees and other bees with this trait are less likely than bees with specialized diets to experience major population changes. In fact, the text makes it clear that like many other wild-bee genera—most of which don’t display dietary generalism—bumblebees are already experiencing population collapse.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

The domestic sweet potato (*Ipomoea batatas*) descends from a wild plant native to South America. It also populates the Polynesian Islands, where evidence confirms that Native Hawaiians and other Indigenous peoples were cultivating the plant centuries before seafaring first occurred over the thousands of miles of ocean separating them from South America. To explain how the sweet potato was first introduced in Polynesia, botanist Pablo Muñoz-Rodríguez and colleagues analyzed the DNA of numerous varieties of the plant, concluding that Polynesian varieties diverged from South American ones over 100,000 years ago. Given that Polynesia was peopled only in the last three thousand years, the team concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. the cultivation of the sweet potato in Polynesia likely predates its cultivation in South America.
- B. Polynesian peoples likely acquired the sweet potato from South American peoples only within the last three thousand years.
- C. human activity likely played no role in the introduction of the sweet potato in Polynesia.
- D. Polynesian sweet potato varieties likely descend from a single South American variety that was domesticated, not wild.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the sweet potato in Polynesia. The text indicates that the sweet potato is found in Polynesia but originated in South America, and that the sweet potato was being cultivated by Native Hawaiians and other Indigenous peoples in Polynesia long before sea voyages between South America and Polynesia began. The text goes on to note that research by Muñoz-Rodríguez and colleagues has established that the Polynesian varieties of sweet potato split from South American varieties more than 100,000 years ago, which is thousands of years before humans settled in Polynesia. If Polynesian peoples were cultivating the sweet potato before sea voyages between Polynesia and South America began, and if Polynesian varieties of sweet potato diverged from South American varieties well before people were in Polynesia, it can reasonably be concluded that humans didn’t play a role in bringing the sweet potato to Polynesia.

Choice A is incorrect. The text doesn’t provide any information about when the sweet potato began to be cultivated in South America, so there’s no support for the conclusion that cultivation began in Polynesia before it began in South America. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that the sweet potato was being cultivated in Polynesia long before sea journeys between Polynesia and South America began. Therefore, it wouldn’t be reasonable to conclude that Polynesian peoples acquired the sweet potato from South American peoples. Additionally, the text indicates that the Polynesian varieties of sweet potato diverged from the South American varieties thousands of years before people settled in Polynesia, which suggests that the sweet potato was already present in Polynesia when people arrived. Choice D is incorrect because the text states that the domestic sweet potato, which is found in Polynesia, descends from a wild South American plant, not from a domesticated South American plant. The only people that the text describes as cultivating the sweet potato are Native Hawaiians and other Indigenous peoples of Polynesia.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

Microbes that live in shallow lakes and ponds produce methane, a harmful greenhouse gas. Ecologist Ralf Aben and his team wanted to see how different types of shallow-water plants might affect the amount of methane that escapes into the atmosphere. Aben’s team set up some water tanks with soil and microbes from local ponds. Some tanks had a type of underwater plant that grows in the soil called watermilfoil. Other tanks had either duckweed, a type of plant that floats on the water’s surface, or algae. Aben and his team found that tanks with duckweed and algae released higher levels of methane than tanks with watermilfoil did. This finding suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. the presence of some kinds of underwater plants like watermilfoil helps prevent methane from escaping shallow lakes and ponds.
- B. shallow lakes and ponds release more methane than deeper bodies of water because shallow bodies of water usually have more plants than deep bodies of water do.
- C. shallow lakes and ponds are more likely to contain algae than to contain either watermilfoil or duckweed.
- D. having a mix of algae, underwater plants, and floating plants is the best way to reduce the amount of methane in shallow lakes and ponds.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The passage tells us that “tanks with duckweed (a floating plant) and algae released higher levels of methane than tanks with watermilfoil (an underwater plant) did.” This suggests that the presence of some kinds of underwater plants like watermilfoil may help prevent methane from escaping shallow lakes and ponds.

Choice B is incorrect. The passage doesn’t mention deeper bodies of water at all, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice C is incorrect. The passage doesn’t compare the likelihood of shallow lakes and ponds containing algae, watermilfoil, or duckweed. Choice D is incorrect. The study didn’t include any tanks with a mix of plants, so there’s no basis for this inference.

Question ID: 8e6a96f5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

Duckweed is a small freshwater plant that is often exposed to zinc pollution. Sofia Vámos and colleagues collected samples of four duckweed ecotypes (genetically and geographically distinct populations within a species), along with water from each ecotype's habitat. Hypothesizing that each ecotype is adapted to its local conditions in ways that bolster its growth and resistance to pollutants, the researchers grew each ecotype in all four water samples and with three levels of zinc (none, low, high). (The researchers did not replicate local differences in light or temperature.) They found that the ecotypes grew equally well in all four water samples and that adding zinc consistently enhanced growth, regardless of concentration, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. while the ecotypes are genetically and geographically distinct, those differences do not represent adaptations to local environmental conditions.
- B. there may not be significant differences in the water that each ecotype inhabits, but there are significant differences in each ecotype's resistance to zinc pollution.
- C. if each ecotype is indeed locally adapted as the researchers hypothesized, those adaptations are to other environmental conditions than the water each ecotype inhabits.
- D. although the researchers' hypothesis does not appear to be supported, this may be because the levels of zinc exposure the plants in the experiment received did not match their exposure in their natural environments.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of Vámos and colleagues' experiment with four duckweed ecotypes. According to the text, the researchers hypothesized that each ecotype is adapted to its local habitat in ways that help it grow more effectively and better tolerate pollutants. To test this, they grew each ecotype in water collected from all four habitats and exposed them to three different zinc levels. If the hypothesis were correct, each ecotype would be expected to thrive more in water from its own habitat than in the other waters and to respond to zinc levels differently depending on the level of zinc pollution in its home environment. However, the results showed that every ecotype grew just as well in every water sample, and that zinc boosted growth the same way across all ecotypes no matter the concentration. In other words, the experiment found no evidence that these ecotypes have specifically adapted to their local water or their local zinc exposure. It follows, then, that if each ecotype is actually locally adapted, it is adapted not to the water conditions in its habitat but to other environmental factors—such as local light or temperature levels, which the text notes the researchers didn't account for in their experiment.

Choice A is incorrect because the findings presented in the text suggest only that the ecotypes' genetic and geographic differences don't represent adaptations to local water conditions and zinc levels, not that the differences don't represent adaptations to *any* local environmental conditions. Indeed, the text notes that the researchers didn't account for light or temperature levels in each habitat, suggesting the possibility that the ecotypes are adapted to those or other local environmental factors. Choice B is incorrect because it contradicts the findings presented in the text. The text states that zinc consistently enhanced growth regardless of concentration, meaning the ecotypes all responded similarly to zinc. This uniform response indicates there *aren't* significant differences in their resistance to zinc pollution. Choice D is incorrect because the findings presented in the text don't demonstrate that the researchers' hypothesis of local adaptation isn't supported. That the ecotypes grew equally well in all of the water samples and equally benefited from added zinc at all levels, regardless of zinc levels in their natural environments, suggests only that the ecotypes aren't adapted to their local water conditions and zinc levels; these findings don't rule out the possibility that the ecotypes are adapted to other local factors in their habitats, such as light or temperature (which the text notes the researchers didn't examine).

Question ID: 7c1e5880

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

Scholars have noted that F. Scott Fitzgerald’s writings were likely influenced in part by his marriage to Zelda Fitzgerald, but many don’t recognize Zelda as a writer in her own right. Indeed, Zelda authored several works herself, such as the novel *Save Me the Waltz* and numerous short stories. Thus, those who primarily view Zelda as an inspiration for F. Scott’s writings _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. overlook the many other factors that motivated F. Scott to write.
- B. risk misrepresenting the full range of Zelda’s contributions to literature.
- C. may draw inaccurate conclusions about how F. Scott and Zelda viewed each other’s works.
- D. tend to read the works of F. Scott and Zelda in an overly autobiographical light.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Zelda Fitzgerald’s contributions to literature. The text begins by saying that many scholars view Zelda mainly in terms of her marriage to F. Scott Fitzgerald and “don’t recognize Zelda as a writer in her own right.” The text then mentions a novel and “numerous short stories” that she wrote and that such scholars tend to ignore. Therefore, those scholars who focus on Zelda only as an inspiration for F. Scott’s writings risk misrepresenting the full range of Zelda’s contributions to literature.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text does mention that Zelda Fitzgerald “likely influenced” her husband’s literary work, its focus is on Zelda’s own writing, not on her husband’s writing or factors that might have influenced it. Choice C is incorrect because the text does not discuss F. Scott and Zelda Fitzgerald’s opinions of each other’s works. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text does suggest that F. Scott Fitzgerald’s works were “likely influenced in part” by his marriage to Zelda, it does not discuss autobiographical interpretations of the works of either F. Scott or Zelda.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

In their book *Smart Pricing*, Jagmohan Raju and Z. John Zhang consider musicians’ use of the nontraditional “pay as you wish” pricing model. This model generally offers listeners the choice to pay more or less than a suggested price for a song or album—or even to pay nothing at all. As the authors note, that’s the option most listeners chose for an album by the band Harvey Danger. Only about 1% opted to pay for the album, resulting in earnings below the band’s expectations. But the authors also discuss musician Jane Siberry, who saw significant earnings from her “pay as you wish” online music store as a result of many listeners choosing to pay more than the store’s suggested prices. Hence, the “pay as you wish” model may _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. prove financially successful for some musicians but disappointing for others.
- B. hold greater financial appeal for bands than for individual musicians.
- C. cause most musicians who use the model to lower the suggested prices of their songs and albums over time.
- D. more strongly reflect differences in certain musicians’ popularity than traditional pricing models do.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. In one example, musicians made less money than expected by using the “pay as you wish” model. In the other example, a musician made more money than expected. This suggests that some musicians may have more success than others using the “pay as you wish” model.

Choice B is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. In the examples provided, the individual musician was more successful with the “pay as you wish” model than the band was. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The passage provides no instances in which musicians changed the suggested prices of their songs or albums, nor does it mention this as a possibility. Choice D is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never discusses the differences in popularity of different musicians, so there is no basis to make this inference.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

The morphological novelty of echinoderms—marine invertebrates with radial symmetry, usually starlike, around a central point—impedes comparisons with most other animals, in which bilateral symmetry on an anterior-posterior (head to tail) axis through a trunk is typical. Particularly puzzling are sea stars, thought to have evolved a headless layout from a known bilateral origin. Applying genomic knowledge of *Saccoglossus kowalevskii* acorn worms (close relatives of sea stars, and thus expected to have similar markers for corresponding anatomical regions) to the body patterning genes of *Patiria miniata* sea stars, Laurent Formery et al. observed activity only in anterior genes across *P. miniata*'s entire body and some posterior genes limited to the edges, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. despite the greater prevalence of anterior genes in sea stars’ genetic makeup, posterior genes active at the body’s perimeter are primarily responsible for the starlike layout that distinguishes sea stars’ radial symmetry from that of other echinoderms.
- B. contrary to the belief that they evolved from early ancestors with the bilateral form typical of many other animals, sea stars instead originated with an atypical body layout that was neither bilaterally nor radially symmetrical.
- C. although the two species are closely related, there is only minimal correspondence in the genetic markers for head, tail, and trunk region development in *P. miniata* sea stars and *S. kowalevskii* acorn worms.
- D. rather than undergoing changes resulting in the eventual elimination of a head region in their radial body plan, as previously assumed, sea stars’ morphology evolved to completely lack a trunk and consist primarily of a head region.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the morphology (form and structure) of sea stars, a type of echinoderm. The text indicates that echinoderms have radially symmetrical body plans (symmetrical around a central point, usually in the form of a star), whereas most animals have bilaterally symmetrical body plans (symmetrical along an axis running from head to tail through a trunk). According to the text, sea stars are unusual echinoderms because, despite their radial body plan, they descended from known bilateral ancestors. This shift in body plan was thought to be a process of losing the genetic markers associated with the head region. The text explains that by comparing the genes of one sea star species (*P. miniata*) to those of a close relative, the acorn worm, researchers determined that instead, anterior (head) genes are active across the sea star’s entire body, posterior (tail) genes are active in limited, peripheral locations of the body, and no trunk-related genes are active. This finding strongly suggests that, rather than becoming "headless" as they evolved from a bilateral ancestor, sea stars developed a body plan consisting almost entirely of a head region with a minimal tail region and no trunk region present.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t identify how any particular region of sea stars’ bodies influences the layout of sea stars’ radial symmetry. Moreover, the text indicates that the radial symmetry of echinoderms is "usually starlike," not that a starlike layout distinguishes sea stars from other echinoderms. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the idea that sea stars evolved from an ancestor with bilateral symmetry is incorrect (describing the bilateral origin as "known") and doesn’t address any body plans other than those with radial or bilateral symmetry. The text strongly suggests that rather than revealing something about sea stars’ origin, Formery et al.’s findings contradict the assumption that the current body plan of sea stars is "headless." Choice C is incorrect because the text suggests that Formery et al. were able to make determinations about *P. miniata* sea stars’ body plan based on the comparability of genetic markers between *P. miniata* and *S. kowalevskii* acorn worms. The text indicates only that little or no activity was observed in certain types of genes associated with body development in *P. miniata*, not that those genes turned out to largely differ from body-development genes in *S. kowalevskii*.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

One theory behind human bipedalism speculates that it originated in a mostly ground-based ancestor that practiced four-legged “knuckle-walking,” like chimpanzees and gorillas do today, and eventually evolved into moving upright on two legs. But recently, researchers observed orangutans, another relative of humans, standing on two legs on tree branches and using their arms for balance while they reached for fruits. These observations may suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. bipedalism evolved because it was advantageous to a tree-dwelling ancestor of humans.
- B. bipedalism must have evolved simultaneously with knuckle-walking and tree-climbing.
- C. moving between the ground and the trees would have been difficult without bipedalism.
- D. a knuckle-walking human ancestor could have easily moved bipedally in trees.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the evolution of bipedalism in humans. According to the text, one potential explanation for humans walking upright on two legs is that the behavior evolved from an ancestor that mostly stayed on the ground and walked on four limbs, as modern chimpanzees and gorillas do. However, the finding that orangutans, also a relative of humans, sometimes stand on two legs in trees while using their arms to balance and reach for fruits suggests another possible explanation: perhaps a tree-dwelling ancestor of humans began moving on two legs because it offered an advantage, such as access to certain foods.

Choice B is incorrect because the finding that modern orangutans (a relative of humans) sometimes stand on two legs in trees doesn’t offer any insight into when either bipedalism or tree-climbing behavior emerged in human ancestors. Additionally, the text indicates that one theory is that bipedalism evolved from a mostly ground-based ancestor that was already practicing knuckle-walking, not that bipedalism and knuckle-walking developed at the same time. Choice C is incorrect because the finding that orangutans (a relative of humans) sometimes stand on two legs in trees doesn’t offer any insight into how difficult it would’ve been to move between the ground and the trees without bipedalism; there’s no suggestion that climbing or moving in trees depends on the ability to walk on two legs rather than four, even if that ability might be helpful in certain circumstances. Choice D is incorrect because the finding that orangutans (a relative of humans) sometimes stand on two legs in trees doesn’t suggest that a knuckle-walking human ancestor could’ve easily moved on two legs in trees. Although the text indicates that bipedalism may have evolved from a human ancestor that mostly stayed on the ground and walked on four limbs, it gives no indication of how easy it would’ve been for such an ancestor to move bipedally in trees.

Question ID: 20000f5f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Easy

Question

Arthur Conan Doyle’s stories about detective Sherlock Holmes were published between 1887 and 1927. They have inspired countless successful adaptations, including comic strips, movies, and a television series *Sherlock Hound*, directed by Hayao Miyazaki, who is celebrated for his animated movies. Until 2014, these stories were copyrighted. The right to adapt was only available to those who could afford the copyright fee and gain approval from the strict copyright holders of Doyle’s estate. Some journalists predict that the number of Sherlock Holmes adaptations is likely to increase since the end of copyright means that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. Doyle’s original stories will become hard to find.
- B. people will become more interested in detective stories than they were in the 1800s.
- C. producing adaptations will become easier and less expensive.
- D. the former copyright holders of Doyle’s estate will return fees they collected.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The text tells us that because of the copyright, adapting Sherlock Holmes stories used to be expensive and difficult. This suggests that after the copyright ends, it will be less expensive and less difficult to adapt these stories.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never suggests that the copyright ending will make Sherlock Holmes stories harder to find. Instead, it suggests that adaptations of these stories will be easier and less expensive to make. Choice B is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never discusses people’s interest in detective stories, so there is no basis to make this inference. Choice D is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never suggests that copyright fees from the past are returned after a copyright ends, so there is no basis to make this inference.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

Songbirds learn to respond to and imitate their species’ songs from an early age. With each generation, small differences are introduced that result in distinct variations—called dialects—among geographically isolated populations of the same species. A research study examined whether twelve-day-old *Ficedula hypoleuca* (pied flycatcher) nestlings prefer local dialects over the unfamiliar dialects of nonlocal *F. hypoleuca* populations: the more begging calls the nestlings made in response to a song, the stronger their preference. The researchers found that nestlings produced more begging calls in response to their own dialect than to nonlocal dialects. Since song preference plays a role in songbird mate selection, the finding suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. *F. hypoleuca* nestlings’ preference for their own dialect likely disappears as they mature to promote socialization between different *F. hypoleuca* populations.
- B. *F. hypoleuca* nestlings who show an early preference for their own dialect are likely to receive more food from their caretakers than nestlings who show no preferences among any *F. hypoleuca* dialects.
- C. *F. hypoleuca* nestlings’ preference for their own dialect likely drives them when they mature to reproduce with other *F. hypoleuca* from local rather than nonlocal populations.
- D. *F. hypoleuca* nestlings show a preference for both local *F. hypoleuca* dialects and the songs of other local songbirds over the songs of nonlocal birds of any species.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. Because “song preference plays a role in songbird mate selection,” and because *F. hypoleuca* nestlings display a preference for local dialects, we can infer that they will be more likely to choose mates from local populations.

Choice A is incorrect. We don’t have any information suggesting that this preference disappears, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice B is incorrect. Although the passage discusses the number of begging calls made in response to various *F. hypoleuca* dialects, no mention is made about the amount of food received based on dialect preference. Therefore, there’s no basis for this inference. Choice D is incorrect. There’s no mention in the passage of methods of other types of local songbirds, so there’s no basis for this inference.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

One challenge when researching whether holding elected office changes a person’s behavior is the problem of ensuring that the experiment has an appropriate control group. To reveal the effect of holding office, researchers must compare people who hold elected office with people who do not hold office but who are otherwise similar to the office-holders. Since researchers are unable to control which politicians win elections, they therefore _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. struggle to find valid data about the behavior of politicians who do not currently hold office.
- B. can only conduct valid studies with people who have previously held office rather than people who presently hold office.
- C. should select a control group of people who differ from office-holders in several significant ways.
- D. will find it difficult to identify a group of people who can function as an appropriate control group for their studies.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the challenge researchers face when studying the effects of holding elected office on a person’s behavior. The text explains that it’s hard for researchers to test for the effects that elected office has on people because finding people to serve as a control group is difficult. The text indicates that a control group needs to be made up of people who share characteristics of the group being tested but don’t have the variable being tested (in this case, holding elected office). Because researchers aren’t able to influence who wins elections, they’re also unable to determine who would serve as an appropriately similar member of a control group. Thus, it logically follows that researchers will find it difficult to identify a group of people who can function as an appropriate control group for their studies.

Choice A is incorrect because the text focuses on the struggle to put together a control group for experiments; it doesn’t suggest that finding information about politicians’ behavior is difficult. Choice B is incorrect because the experiments mentioned in the text are testing the effects of holding elected office on a person’s behavior. Studying people who have already held elected office wouldn’t provide an opportunity to note any behavioral changes that the position might cause. Choice C is incorrect because the text defines people in a control group as those "who are otherwise similar to the office-holders"; selecting people who differ from the office-holders wouldn’t fit the criteria for an appropriate control group.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Easy

Question

One aspect of in-person shopping that online shopping can’t replicate is the opportunity to touch a product before buying it. Does this difference matter? In an experiment, researchers asked one group of participants to touch a mug and a toy, while another group was prohibited from touching the two items. The participants were then asked how much money they’d pay for the items. People who got to touch the items were willing to pay much more money for them than were people who weren’t allowed to touch the items. This finding suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. people who mainly shop online probably spend more money every month than people who mainly shop in person do.
- B. in-person shopping may make products seem more valuable than they seem if only viewed online.
- C. retailers with in-person and online stores should charge the same price for a given product in both places.
- D. online retailers may be able to raise the prices they charge for products that are only available online.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text tells us that “people who got to touch the items were willing to pay much more money for them than people who weren’t allowed to touch” them. This suggests that being able to interact with a product in person may make it seem more valuable to a shopper.

Choice A is incorrect. The text doesn’t discuss how much people spend each month, so there’s not much basis for this claim. Furthermore, since being able to touch a product tends to make people “willing to pay much more money” for it, we might predict that an online shopper would be willing to spend less on the same purchases as an in-person shopper. Choice C is incorrect. The text doesn’t discuss what retailers “should charge,” so there’s not much basis for this claim. Furthermore, the study in the text suggests that in-person stores may actually be able to charge more for a given product, since shoppers can touch it. Choice D is incorrect. The text doesn’t discuss products that are only available online, so there’s not much basis for this claim. Furthermore, products only available online would still have the problem of shoppers not being able to touch them, and the study suggests that this lowers the prices shoppers are willing to pay.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

A social species, chickens will cry out to one another in warning if they sense a hawk or other predator nearby. But if alone, a chicken will remain silent so as not to attract the predator’s attention. Sonja Hillemacher decided to use this behavior to determine whether individual chickens possess a capacity to recognize themselves visually when reflected in a mirror (a common standard for animal intelligence). In the first condition of her study, the subject could see its reflection, but no other chickens were present. In a second condition, another chicken was visible to the subject. Hillemacher presented an image of a hawk to the subject in both conditions, reasoning that if chickens lacked a capacity for visual self-recognition, then _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. neither study condition would elicit an audible response from the subject.
- B. the subject likely would cry out a warning in both study conditions.
- C. only the first study condition would elicit an audible response from the subject.
- D. the subject would fail to distinguish its reflection from the image of the hawk.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Hillemacher’s study of visual self-recognition in chickens. According to the text, when a predator is nearby, chickens cry out in warning if another chicken is present but remain silent if alone to avoid attracting the predator’s attention. The text explains that Hillemacher set up one condition in which a subject was alone and could see its reflection in a mirror and another condition in which the subject could see another chicken, and then presented an image of a hawk (a predator). It follows that if chickens aren’t capable of recognizing themselves visually in a mirror, the subject likely would cry out a warning in both conditions; in the first condition because it would perceive its reflection as another chicken—that is, it would think another chicken is present—and in the second condition because it would see that another chicken is actually present.

Choice A is incorrect because the text suggests that regardless of chickens’ ability to visually recognize themselves in mirrors, the subject in the second condition would cry out a warning because another chicken is actually present. Further, if chickens do lack visual self-recognition, the subject in the first condition likely would also cry out because it would think its reflection is another chicken. Choice C is incorrect. The text does suggest that if chickens lack the ability to visually recognize themselves in mirrors, the subject would cry out a warning in the first condition because it would think its reflection is another chicken. However, the text also indicates that regardless of their capacity of self-recognition, chickens cry out a warning when other chickens are present, and another chicken is present in the second condition. Therefore, both conditions—not just the first one—likely would elicit an audible response from the subject. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that the study was focused on determining whether chickens recognize themselves visually in a mirror or instead perceive their reflections as other chickens; there’s no suggestion that a lack of self-recognition would cause a chicken to confuse its reflection with the image of a hawk.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

German theater practitioner Bertolt Brecht (1898–1956) believed that theater should elicit an intellectual rather than an emotional response from audiences, provoking them to consider social and political realities that extend beyond the characters and events depicted onstage. Brecht’s influence can be seen in English playwright Caryl Churchill’s 1979 play *Cloud 9*: although the play sometimes invites empathetic reactions, it primarily works to engage audiences in an interrogation of patriarchy and colonialism, which it does by placing audiences at a distance, thereby encouraging them to _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. focus on the characters’ beliefs about social and political issues as revealed by the characters’ actions.
- B. reflect on social and political phenomena not directly related to patriarchy and colonialism.
- C. recognize pertinent social and political parallels between Germany during Brecht’s time and England at the time when Churchill was writing *Cloud 9*.
- D. be dispassionate as they think critically about the social and political questions raised by the play.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Churchill’s play was influenced by Brecht’s belief that theater should elicit an intellectual rather than an emotional response from audiences, making them think about social and political issues that also exist outside of the play. Therefore, it makes sense that Churchill would strive to have audiences think dispassionately (i.e., without emotion) and critically about the social and political questions raised by the play.

Choice A is incorrect. The passage mentions that Churchill was influenced by Brecht’s belief that plays should provoke audience members “to consider social and political realities that extend beyond the characters and events depicted onstage,” so there’s no basis for an inference about audience members deeply engaging with characters’ beliefs and actions. Choice B is incorrect. Reflecting on things that aren’t related to patriarchy and colonialism wouldn’t “engage audiences in an interrogation of patriarchy and colonialism.” That creates a confusing contradiction. Choice C is incorrect. No mention is made of social and political issues in Germany during Brecht’s time, so there’s no basis for this inference.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

Archaeologists and historians used to believe that the Maya civilization during its Classic period (roughly 250–900) lacked agricultural marketplaces. One reason for this belief was that these scholars misunderstood the ecology of the regions the Maya inhabited. Marketplaces typically emerge because different individuals or groups want to trade resources they control for resources they don't control. Scholars seriously underestimated the ecological diversity of the Maya landscape and thus assumed that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. marketplaces likely would not have attracted many traders from outside the regions controlled by the Maya.
- B. farming practices would have been largely the same throughout Maya lands even if the crops people produced varied significantly.
- C. marketplaces would not have enabled Maya people to acquire many products different from those they already produced.
- D. farmers would trade agricultural products only if they had already produced enough to meet their own needs.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text's discussion of scholars' understanding of Maya ecology and agricultural marketplaces. The text indicates that scholars used to believe that during the Classic period, the Maya civilization didn't have agricultural marketplaces. According to the text, scholars held this view because they misunderstood the ecology of areas where the Maya lived. The text points out that people tend to create marketplaces in order to acquire resources they don't otherwise control. Agricultural marketplaces would have allowed farmers who produced one type of crop to trade that crop for other types of crops that they didn't produce. The text goes on to say, however, that scholars underestimated the ecological diversity of the Maya areas, meaning that scholars thought that the Maya landscape produced a smaller range of resources than it actually produced. Taken together, then, this information suggests that scholars assumed that marketplaces wouldn't have allowed Maya people to acquire products different from the products they already produced: that is, if everyone produced the same array of crops, as scholars mistakenly believed, then there wouldn't have been any need for marketplaces where people could trade those crops.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn't say anything about trade between the Maya and people from outside the regions controlled by the Maya. Although scholars' mistaken belief that the Maya lands weren't very ecologically diverse would give those scholars a reason to think that the Maya didn't have marketplaces, it wouldn't lead scholars to assume that traders from outside Maya lands were uninterested in acquiring resources produced by the Maya. Even if the Maya actually did produce only a small array of resources throughout their lands, there is no reason to believe from the text that people outside Maya lands also produced these same resources and thus would have no need to trade with the Maya people. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that scholars underestimated the ecological diversity of the Maya lands, which suggests that they mistakenly believed that the Maya produced a relatively small array of resources throughout their territory, not that the crops the Maya produced varied significantly throughout the Maya lands. Although the scholars might have assumed that a lack of ecological diversity suggests that Maya farming practices were largely the same everywhere, the text does not support that they also assumed there was a lot of variation in the crops that Maya people produced. In fact, the text states that marketplaces emerge when people want to obtain resources they don't already control. If it were the case that scholars assumed that the crops Maya people produced varied significantly, this would have led them to conclude that Maya people likely established marketplaces so they could trade for resources they didn't already possess, not that the Maya civilization lacked marketplaces. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that scholars assumed that farmers wouldn't trade their agricultural products unless they had already met their own needs with those products. Instead, the text says that scholars thought that the Maya lands produced a smaller array of resources than they actually did, which the text suggests led scholars to assume that the Maya

didn't have any need for marketplaces. The scholars' mistaken belief has no bearing on the issue of whether farmers met their own needs before trading their products.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

The alpaca was domesticated by Indigenous peoples in the Andes about 7,000 years ago. But which wild species did it descend from, the vicuña or guanaco? A research team led by Ruiwen Fan may have solved the mystery, concluding that the alpaca is the domesticated form of the vicuña but that the modern alpaca gets only 64 percent of its genetic material from its wild ancestor. The rest comes from the domesticated llama. The llama, meanwhile, gets 95.5 percent of its genetic material from its own wild ancestor, the guanaco, and the rest from the alpaca. The llama and alpaca apparently interbred widely for only a handful of generations between 400 and 600 years ago. Assuming that the findings of Fan’s team are valid, it can be inferred that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. modern llama populations have a greater degree of genetic diversity, on average, than modern alpaca populations do.
- B. the domestication process of the alpaca may have involved some introduction of genetic material from the llama.
- C. the period of interbreeding resulted in a greater genetic difference between alpacas and their wild ancestors than between llamas and their wild ancestors.
- D. if they were subjected to genetic testing, modern populations of guanacos and vicuñas would likely show traces of ancient interbreeding as well.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the inference that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the genetic material of alpacas. The text states that modern alpacas get only 64 percent of their genetic material from their wild ancestor (the vicuña), while llamas get 95.5 percent of their genetic material from their wild ancestor (the guanaco). These data imply that relative to llamas, alpacas have experienced a much greater genetic shift away from their wild ancestors (36 percent of their genetic material derives from another source, compared to 4.5 percent of llamas’ genetic material). Moreover, the text establishes that the remainder of alpacas’ genetic material derives from llamas, and the remainder of llamas’ genetic material derives from alpacas, reflecting a period of interbreeding. Taken together, these details support the inference that the period of interbreeding had a more significant impact on the genetic material of alpacas than on that of llamas, thereby reducing the percentage of alpacas’ genetic material that derives from wild ancestors and placing alpacas at a greater remove from these ancestors.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t provide information about genetic diversity within modern llama and alpaca populations. While the text discusses the percentage of genetic material each domesticated species inherited from its wild ancestor and from interbreeding, it does not address the level of genetic variation within each species. Therefore, it isn’t logical to infer that modern llama populations have a greater degree of genetic diversity than modern alpaca populations do. Choice B is incorrect because it contradicts the chronology presented in the text. The text states that alpacas were domesticated about 7,000 years ago, but the interbreeding with llamas occurred “between 400 and 600 years ago.” The genetic mixing happened thousands of years after domestication, not during it; in addition, the text does not provide details about what the process of domestication might entail. Therefore, it isn’t logical to infer that llama genetic material was introduced during the domestication process of alpacas. Choice D is incorrect because though the text notes that guanacos and vicuñas contributed to the genetic material of alpacas and llamas, it only discusses alpacas’ and llamas’ genetic composition. Therefore, the text does not support the inference that modern populations of guanacos and vicuñas would likely show traces of ancient interbreeding.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Hard

Question

The ratio of methane to other atmospheric constituents—represented by a measure called the methane mole fraction—influences a variety of meteorological phenomena, notably precipitation and humidity. For Titan, Saturn’s largest moon, the observational data that exist are too sparse and discrepant to fully constrain the range of the methane mole fraction at various atmospheric levels. Juan Lora and colleagues point out that outputs of the IPSL atmospheric model of Titan, which track closely to observations in some respects, reflect how the model’s developers responded to this challenge: by prescribing a uniform methane mole fraction for the lowest level of the atmosphere. It is therefore important to note that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. some disagreements between the model’s simulations of Titan’s precipitation and humidity and the moon’s actual precipitation and humidity are to be expected.
- B. further observations of Titan may clarify the moon’s methane mole fraction sufficiently for the model to employ a single value rather than a range.
- C. even though the model’s outputs sometimes agree with observational data, Titan’s real methane mole fraction is likely higher than the methane mole fraction used in the model.
- D. inconsistencies across the model’s simulations of Titan’s precipitation and humidity could be attributable to variations in the moon’s methane mole fraction.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of modeling the atmosphere of Titan. The text establishes that the methane mole fraction (the ratio of methane to other atmospheric components) influences precipitation, humidity, and other meteorological phenomena and that observational data for Titan are too lacking (“too sparse and discrepant”) to fully determine the range of this measure across the moon’s various atmospheric levels. The text indicates that because of this limitation, researchers developed an atmospheric model (IPSL) that uses a simplified approach: it applies a uniform methane mole fraction for the lowest atmospheric level. Since it is very unlikely that the actual methane distribution across atmospheric levels on Titan is uniform, and since the methane mole fraction directly affects precipitation and humidity, it logically follows that the model’s simplified treatment of the methane mole fraction would lead to some disagreements between the model’s simulations and Titan’s actual precipitation and humidity.

Choice B is incorrect because the text makes it clear that the model *already* uses a single value for Titan’s methane mole fraction instead of a range. Further, the text suggests that the single value is a simplification of what is likely a more complex reality, so there’s no reason to assume that a single value would be more desirable than a range. Choice C is incorrect. The text strongly suggests that Titan’s actual methane mole fraction differs from the uniform value used in the model, even though some of the model’s outputs align closely with observations, but nothing in the text indicates how the actual value would differ. There’s no reason to assume that the actual methane mole fraction is higher than what the model uses. The “lowest level” mentioned in the text refers to the atmosphere and not Titan’s methane mole fraction. Choice D is incorrect because the text makes it clear that the model *doesn’t* reflect the actual variations in the methane mole fraction across Titan’s atmospheric levels, since observational data are too limited. Because the model uniformly applies a set methane mole fraction, no inconsistencies in the simulations would be attributable to actual variations in the moon’s methane mole fraction.

Question ID: 3cc2eacc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

In a study of the mechanisms underlying associative memory—or the ability to learn and remember connections between inherently unrelated things—neuroscientists Kei Igarashi, Jasmine Chavez, and others presented mice with memory tests. The team discovered that fan cells, a type of cell found in the medial temporal lobe of the brain, are necessary for the acquisition of new associative memories. They also found that fan cell activity requires dopamine, a chemical the brain produces in response to pleasure and rewards. Consequently, receiving a reward should likely help to _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. decrease an individual's capacity to utilize dopamine.
- B. increase an individual's capacity to recognize differences between unrelated things.
- C. increase an individual's capacity to form associative memories.
- D. decrease an individual's capacity to create fan cells.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of the mechanisms underlying associative memory. The text explains that fan cells—a type of brain cell—are necessary for the acquisition of new associative memories, and that activity among these cells requires a chemical known as dopamine, which the brain produces in response to rewards. Since the brain cells that enable the formation of associative memories require dopamine in order to function, and since the brain produces dopamine in response to rewards, it can be inferred that receiving a reward should likely help to increase an individual's capacity to form associative memories.

Choice A is incorrect because the relationship between rewards and dopamine sketched by the text is that rewards result in the production of dopamine, not that they cause an individual's capacity to utilize dopamine to decrease. Choice B is incorrect. The text suggests that receiving a reward would produce dopamine and thereby assist with associative memory formation. However, the text never suggests that associative memory involves the capacity to recognize differences between unrelated things, indicating only that associative memory involves remembering what connects those things. Choice D is incorrect because the text never discusses how fan cells are initially created and therefore provides no evidence for a conclusion about how receiving a reward would affect their creation.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

Pablo Picasso famously subverted the norms of traditional painting: in his cubist paintings he refused to let his expression be constrained, fragmenting objects and figures to present multiple perspectives simultaneously. Though less widely known, Picasso—who once lamented that writers of his time had “limited themselves to moving around words somewhat while respecting the syntax”—also wrote poetry that defied conventional grammar, semantic relationships, and text structure. Thus, the paintings and poems are linked in that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. the poems present many of the same subjects as the paintings but with different thematic approaches.
- B. the poems are intended to be understood as explanations of the artistic inclinations reflected in the paintings.
- C. both types of work are characterized by the simultaneous representation of multiple points of view that Picasso is known for.
- D. both exhibit Picasso’s prioritization of creative expression over the standard rules of the art forms.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the link between Picasso’s cubist paintings and his poetry. The text states that Picasso subverted, or intentionally went against, the norms of traditional painting; rather than following conventional rules about how paintings should look, he fragmented objects and figures to present multiple perspectives at the same time. The text explains that similarly, Picasso wrote poetry that defied conventions of grammar, semantics, and structure. Because Picasso subverted the conventions of both painting and written language in favor of unconstrained expression, it is reasonable to conclude that his paintings and poems are linked by their demonstration of his prioritization of creative expression over the standard rules of the art forms.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t give any information about the subjects or themes of either Picasso’s paintings or his poems; it indicates only that Picasso didn’t adhere to the norms of either art form. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text explains that the forms of Picasso’s paintings and his poems demonstrate his inclination to not be constrained by convention, it doesn’t discuss any of the ideas expressed in his poems; there’s no indication that Picasso intended his poems to be understood as explanations of anything reflected in his paintings. Choice C is incorrect. The text mentions the simultaneous representation of multiple points of view as a characteristic of Picasso’s cubist paintings but doesn’t indicate that his poems had the same characteristic; the text doesn’t address perspective in Picasso’s poems at all.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	Medium

Question

Although military veterans make up a small proportion of the total population of the United States, they occupy a significantly higher proportion of the jobs in the civilian government. One possible explanation for this disproportionate representation is that military service familiarizes people with certain organizational structures that are also reflected in the civilian government bureaucracy, and this familiarity thus _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

Answer

- A. makes civilian government jobs especially appealing to military veterans.
- B. alters the typical relationship between military service and subsequent career preferences.
- C. encourages nonveterans applying for civilian government jobs to consider military service instead.
- D. increases the number of civilian government jobs that require some amount of military experience to perform.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of military veterans working in civilian government jobs in the United States. The text indicates that the proportion of military veterans working in civilian government jobs is considerably higher than the proportion of military veterans in the population as a whole. The text also notes that the unusually high representation of military veterans in these jobs may be a result of the organizational structures shared by civilian government entities and the military. Hence, it’s reasonable to infer that it’s the familiarity of the structures of civilian government that makes jobs there particularly attractive to military veterans.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t address what a typical relationship between military service and later career preferences would be, and there’s no indication that it’s atypical for veterans to work in civilian government jobs after they’ve left the military. On the contrary, the text suggests that many military veterans are drawn to such jobs. Choice C is incorrect because the text is focused on the high representation of military veterans in civilian government jobs and doesn’t address nonveterans or their possible interest in military service. Choice D is incorrect because the text conveys that military veterans may be particularly interested in civilian government jobs due to the familiarity of organizational structures that are already in place, but there’s no reason to think that this interest would mean that more civilian government jobs will start to require military experience.